Sustainability describes a food system as it is. But *real* sustainability — which includes *survivability* — describes whether it keeps being a food system if the conditions change.

Karen Pendergrass began thinking about the framework that became this book fifteen years ago while watching *The Walking Dead*, asking what would happen to our food systems if there were a zombie apocalypse. The question began unserious. But after fifteen years of pulling on threads through certification audits, fossil records, human-microbiome and heavy-metals research, and asking what an *antifragile* agricultural system would actually look like, the question seemed more important now than ever. Increasingly so.

The Sustainability Diet calls the missing axis *survivability*, builds a four-axis assessment around it, and applies it: industrial grain monoculture, pasture-raised livestock, fisheries, indigenous foodways, urban and bioregional systems, cultivated meat, closed-loop aquaponics.

The book arrives at a moment when the question has stopped being hypothetical. Grain corridors, fertilizer chokepoints, and the food-resilience math behind national security have made the survivability axis a diagnostic the world is now running in real time. The United States arrives at this conversation carrying a structural disadvantage that traces back twelve and a half thousand years — one the framework argues it can get ahead of.

And the question ends in another question the book earns the right to ask: *is the food system that scores best on all four axes one the Americas lost twelve and a half thousand years ago, and could we choose to bring back?*

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Karen Pendergrass founded the Paleo Foundation in 2010 and has spent sixteen years writing food-certification standards from inside the system this book takes apart. She lives in California.

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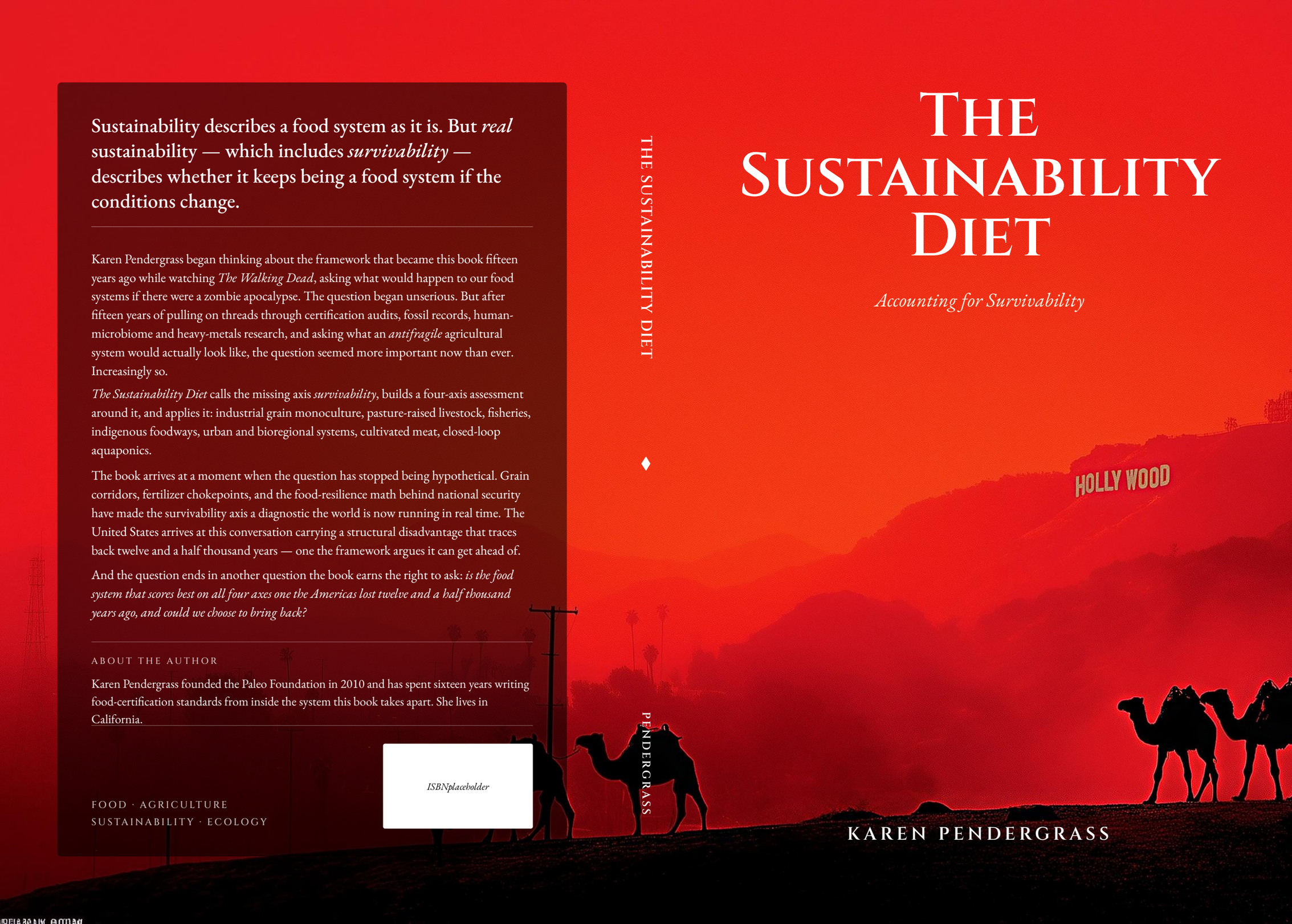
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Accounting for Survivability



KAREN PENDERGRASS